

Silent heroes: (Facing page) Long after the medals are forgotten, it is the warmth and patience of Glasgow's volunteers that will remain one of the Diary's enduring memories of the Commonwealth Games. GETTYIMAGES

It was only fitting, then, that at the Closing Ceremony they received one of the loudest rounds of applause. They deserved every bit of it. Their tireless efforts played a significant role in the success of the Games.

The bus that never came

One of the biggest shortcomings of the Games, however, was the absence of dedicated shuttle buses for journalists travelling between venues.

Around 9 p.m. on July 30, news broke that Seema Kaliramna had won the bronze medal in the women's discus throw. A few television journalists and I waited for transport to Scotstoun Stadium when a bus finally arrived.

When we requested permission to board, the staff refused, insisting that it was reserved for athletes.

"But there are no athletes inside. There are only four of us. Please let us in," we pleaded.

The staff remained unmoved.

"If I let you in, I'll lose my job," one official said.

Left with no choice, we returned to the Moxy Hotel, where the Indian contingent's Chef de Mission had set up office, hoping Seema might eventually arrive there.

A ride home

After being dropped at George Square around 11 p.m. by the official shuttle, I was told I could catch a bus to Yoker from there. As I searched for the bus stop, a smartly dressed six-foot-tall man walked out of a nearby hotel.

I asked him for directions to my accommodation.

He glanced at the address and, without hesitation, said, "Come with me. I'll drop you home."

I politely declined twice, but he would not take no for an answer.



Proud tradition: New Zealand's David Liti receives his men's +110kg gold medal as teammates perform the traditional haka, one of the most stirring celebrations witnessed during the weightlifting competition at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. GETTYIMAGES

"This area isn't very safe because of immigration-related issues," he said.

During the drive, I learnt that my good samaritan was Waseem, a Pakistani businessman born and brought up in Glasgow, whose ancestors hailed from Rawalpindi.

The drive soon turned into a delightful conversation about Bollywood.

"I love Kishore Kumar, Mohammed Rafi and S. P. Balasubrahmanyam," he said.

He dropped me at my accommodation — a place even Google Maps might have struggled to find.

If that isn't hospitality, what is?

The Nail Bar capital

In many ways, Glasgow resembles any large Indian city, except that it is strikingly quiet and serene.

One thing that immediately caught my attention was the sheer number of nail salons. Almost every other street seemed to have one, with women regularly stepping in for manicures.

Curious, I asked two women

about the popularity of nail care.

One of them smiled and said, "I don't go there."

Her friend quickly replied, "I do, every now and then. It's very relaxing and soothing."

The adrenaline within

Reduced to tears after withdrawing from the men's high jump because of a recurring knee injury, Tejaswin Shankar responded in the only way he knew how — by scripting history.

The Indian clinched a memorable bronze medal in the decathlon, becoming the country's first Commonwealth Games medallist in the event.

What drives him in one of athletics' most demanding disciplines, especially while carrying an injury and competing in biting cold? The 27-year-old has a simple explanation. "In these conditions, in such an environment, that's what I'm looking for. Somewhere, I get a kick out of that competitiveness. I like it when I'm in a position where I can chase something, but it's not guaranteed. I like to be in that position. I think I'm an adrenaline